Well, at the moment it feels like they're not really bothered either way.'

There wasn't time to sit at home and wait to see how things might turn out. This wasn't a situation I was in control of anyway. I was off to South Africa for an exhibition game with England. That trip ended in another ride in the back of an ambulance after I broke a bone in my hand early on in the game. Then it was home and a rush to pack bags and get off on our summer vacation in the States. The traveling backwards and forwards was just about right: just how I felt. I didn't know what was going to happen: one day I'd be feeling my time was up at United, the next that things could still be worked out for me to stay. Tony kept me up to date with what was going on back in England. He's always had a good relationship with the United people—the manager apart—and they were honest with each other about what was going on. The club were talking to some of Spain's and Italy's biggest clubs. So was my agent.

As far as I was concerned, signing a new United deal was still possible. Most days, despite everything, it was still what I wanted to do. That made what happened next even more of a bolt from the blue. While in the States, we were staying out at a resort in the desert, relaxing away from it all. I'd just woken up one morning. There was a message on my cell phone from Dave Gardner.

'Have you heard what's on the news? Are you all right about it?'

All the time we were away, I knew there'd been stories claiming I was rushing around trying to look busy, making a name for myself in America. I assumed Dave was talking about that stuff. I replied to him:

'Yeah, fine. Don't worry about it.'

Minutes later, Tony was on the phone to put me straight. The story had come as a complete surprise to him as well. We knew—everyone knew—that Barcelona were one of the clubs who were interested in signing me and that one of the candidates in the presidential election at the club had promised to bring me to Spain if he won. It was a huge jump, though, to the press release issued by Manchester United that Tony read out to me over the phone:

'Manchester United confirms that club officials have met Joan Laporta, the leading candidate for the Presidency of Barcelona. These meetings have resulted in an offer being made for the transfer of David Beckham to Barcelona. This offer is subject to a number of conditions and critically to both Mr Laporta being elected President on Sunday June 15 and Barcelona